

# Things That Feel

Human ⇔ Object in Television and Art

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## Abstract

Consumption of art often demands the audience to project themselves onto the art object. **Are there ways for the object and human experience to exchange roles? This thesis will look at object-to-human expressions in anthropomorphic characters on television that instigate a relational viewing of the material through fan culture and semiotics.** Case studies include the South Korean TV series "Chicken Nugget" (2024) and an episode titled "Pickle Rick" (2017) of the American TV series "Rick and Morty". **Additionally, I will consider a phenomenological and relational view of embodiment in interactive art as evidence of human-to-object experiences.** Case studies include the immersive, interactive works of Canadian artist Char Davies and Australian artist Simon Penny. My primary sources are "Relational Aesthetics" (1998) by Nicolas Bourriaud, "Object-oriented Ontology and the Other of We in Anthropocentric Posthumanism" by Yogi Hale Hendlin (2023) and "The Implicit Body as Performance: Analyzing Interactive Art" by Nathaniel Stern (2011).

Keywords: relational aesthetic, anthropomorphism, phenomenology, OOO, posthumanism, semiotics in television, immersive and interactive arts, fan culture

## Introduction

As “things” that feel, humans, for as long as we have been around, have held a desire to manifest ideas into materials or objects of expression. The presentation of this form by an artist for a viewer creates a possibility of exchange. *“Producing a form is to invent possible encounters; receiving a form is to create the conditions for an exchange...form is the representative of desire in the image”*.<sup>1</sup> Traditional art mediums, such as painting and sculpture, offer such encounters, primarily in visual forms. In the world of immersive art, it could be hypothesised that the audience’s interaction with the artworks becomes part of its form. It is here where the human could be potentially seen as the object. In moving image, we often see anthropomorphic objects as forms of expression which reveal the mortal desire of relatability and empathy. So, exactly where do objects begin and when can they become us?

This text borrows its title from Mario Perniola’s text on contemporary philosophy around the notion that society is shifting from organic to inorganic sensuality. *“It would seem that things and senses are no longer in conflict with one another but have struck an alliance thanks to which the most detached abstraction and the most unrestrained excitement are almost inseparable and are often indistinguishable”*.<sup>2</sup> My interpretation of this text is to take “detached abstraction” here as a reference to surreal, absurd visualities and “unrestrained excitement” as a reference to audience consumption of art and media, while analysing the relationship between human sensibility and object experiences in two artistic contexts: television and interactive.

## Object-to-human in Television

French curator and art critic, Nicolas Bourriaud is credited for defining relational aesthetics and art. Although he did not perceive television as a relational medium<sup>3</sup>, the landscape of television today is different from the moment he expressed his views on it.<sup>4</sup> Consumption of televised material no

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<sup>1</sup> Bourriaud, N. (1998) Relational Aesthetics. Dijon, Burgundy: Les Presses du Réel. (Accessed: 10 January 2024)

<sup>2</sup> Perinola, M. (2017) ‘Senses and Things’, in The Sex Appeal of the Inorganic. New York, New York: Bloomsbury, pp. 1–1., (Accessed: 10 January 2024).

<sup>3</sup> “Relational art: A set of artistic practises which take as their theoretical and practical point of departure the whole of human relations and their social context, rather than an independent and private space” (Bourriaud, 1998).

<sup>4</sup> “Art (practices stemming from painting and sculpture which come across in the form of an exhibition) turns out to be particularly suitable when it comes to expressing this hands-on civilisation, because it

longer relies on television screens for their dissemination. The limitations set by cable or satellite television are being eliminated by the rise of television over the internet. Additionally, the immediacy of the internet has caused a sharp increase in accessibility and presence. Signs and meanings of the content itself are being dissected actively and continuously by wide networks of audiences around the world, crossing boundaries of language and culture.

## Fans of Television

I will begin by looking at an episode from *Rick and Morty* which is titled *Pickle Rick*. Created in 2013 by Dan Harmon and Justin Roiland, this series is a widely known American animated sci-fi sitcom, with a strong tendency towards the absurd and the surreal while dealing with sensitive issues such as family, authority, and addictions. The episode follows Rick (who falls under the mad scientist trope) as he transforms himself into a pickle to avoid a therapy session with his family and consequently faces multiple life-threatening situations. The writers of the episode have talked about the concept coming up intuitively as an obvious situation the character would get himself into.<sup>5</sup> He has been set up as an incredibly intelligent but troubled man with a predisposition to create problems as opposed to solutions, hence often being the architect of his own struggles. Rick's self-imposed transformation into a pickle functions as a punchline while creating a metaphoric object that deepens his character in the viewer's perception.<sup>6,7</sup> Since this is an animated work, there is already a keen sense of detachment from reality which is further deepened by centring an anthropomorphic figure. However, the viewer's faith in the story is strengthened by the nature of the fandom around this series.

The collective and memetic behaviour displayed by the *Rick and Morty* fandom is rooted in its active online presence. Message boards and comment

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tightens the space of relations, unlike TV and literature which refer each individual person to his or her space of private consumption, and also unlike theatre and cinema which bring small groups together specific, unmistakable images. Actually, there is no live comment made about what is seen (the discussion is put off until after the show)" (Bourriaud, 1998).

<sup>5</sup> Berkowitz, J. (2017) Pickle Rick and space prison: Inside "Rick and Morty" Season 3 with Dan Harmon, FastCompany. Available at: <https://www.fastcompany.com/40461815/pickle-rick-and-space-prison-inside-rick-and-morty-season-3-with-dan-harmon> (Accessed: 10 June 2024).

<sup>6</sup> Greene, S. (2017) 'Rick and Morty' review: 'Pickle Rick' turns the simplest premise into a spectacular action animation showcase, IndieWire. Available at: <https://www.indiewire.com/criticism/shows/rick-and-morty-season-3-episode-3-review-pickle-rick-recap-spoilers-1201864053/> (Accessed: 10 June 2024).

<sup>7</sup> Hellerman, J. (2024) What 'Pickle Rick' can teach us about character goals and obstacles, No Film School. Available at: <https://nofilmschool.com/pickel-rick> (Accessed: 10 June 2024).

chains are flooded with chatter and emotion with every new episode or promotional release. According to Lori Hitchcock Morimoto and Bertha Chin, *“when such fans are able to participate in a real-time fannish moment [...] the sense of camaraderie produced by this shared and intensely affective experience, regardless of perceived language and cultural barriers, cannot be overstated”*.<sup>8</sup> This immediacy and intensity add to the strengthened commitment of the viewer to the story and its progress. Through active and continuous circulation of the community’s views and theories, they reaffirm a sense of belief in its reality. This results in what I argue can be understood as a 'relational viewing'.

Given the current state of television consumption, viewers inadvertently find themselves online and in communication with each other as they consume a series like *Rick and Morty*.<sup>9</sup> These inter-human networks suggest a relational aesthetic reading of *Pickle Rick*’s central object instead of the speculative materialist readings of Object-Oriented Ontology (OOO). Yogi Hale Hendlin in his paper from 2023 writes about the flaws based on OOO’s ontological flattening of its subjects and alternatively presents his support for relational ontology. *“Since the self is relational, material, and interdependent, and the Earth and the organisms we evolved with are the bedrock for our health, meaning, and culture, redefining the self as relational rather than as ontologically individual, circumscribed, and alienated, enables us to wed our animal drives with planetary politics”*.<sup>10</sup> Considering the meaning-making processes instigated by inter-human networks of online fan communities, this relational understanding highlights the interdependency between viewer and material. While the form used to portray *Pickle Rick* is anthropomorphic, what happens when the human identity is semiotically projected onto an object?

## Semiotics of Television

An instance of this can be found in a South Korean drama titled, *Chicken Nugget* (the Korean title translates to Sweet and Spicy Chicken). Based on a webcomic by Park Ji-Dok, it was adapted for television, directed by Lee Byeong-Hun, and released in March 2024. It follows the CEO of a company that builds

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<sup>8</sup> Morimoto, L.H. and Chin, B. (2017) ‘Reimagining the Imagined Community’, in *Fandom Identities and Communities in a Mediated World*. Second. New York City, New York: NYU Press, pp. 174–187. Available at: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1pwtbq2> (Accessed: 18 June 2024).

<sup>9</sup> Gaudette, E. (2018) Is something wrong with ‘Rick and Morty’ fans?, *Newsweek*. Available at: <https://www.newsweek.com/whats-wrong-rick-and-morty-fans-how-adult-swim-nerds-became-meme-824581> (Accessed: 18 June 2024).

<sup>10</sup> Hendlin, Y.H. (2023) ‘Object-Oriented ontology and the other of we in anthropocentric posthumanism’, *Zygon*, 58(2), pp. 315–339. doi:10.1111/zygo.12864. (Accessed: 10 January 2024)

“machines” and his intern who harbours romantic feelings for his boss’ daughter. When the daughter is turned into a chicken nugget by a mysterious machine, a series of events are set off all rooted in the struggles of the protagonists. *Chicken Nugget* is also a sci-fi comedy employing the surreal and the absurd to tell a deeply human and emotional story about family and relationships. But unlike the *Pickle Rick* episode, this show features a non-anthropomorphic representation of a humanised object. In the present reality, “she” is physically rendered as a chicken nugget without any human qualities. Any sense of attachment to this visually inhuman material relies on the expression of emotion by the other characters, achieved through dialogue, flashbacks and imaginary situations. Here, semiotics of TV-making plays a crucial role in an increased sense of believability.

In one flashback, we see the father reminiscing about her childhood, from when he lost his wife during childbirth to becoming a single father and building a loving, nourishing environment for his daughter. This montage sets up the emotional core of the interpersonal struggles around the tragedy of his daughter becoming a chicken nugget. But not every viewer is guaranteed to feel an emotional tug. The more we consume tragic content, the possibility of desensitisation increases *“with each successive tragic work, we become that much more accustomed—acclimated—to the tragic form, and as a result our tragic sensibility grows at once more refined and less responsive, more cerebral and less affectively responsive”*.<sup>11</sup> On the other hand, a casual viewer of Korean dramas would express a sense of shock when discussing the premise of this show because it is simply too absurd to exist in their conventional perception of a Korean drama.<sup>12</sup> In *Semiotics of Television*, Fiske notes the issue of whether established realism will inevitably defuse the radicalism of any radical content. Through a combination of its presence on Netflix and idiosyncratic film language, *Chicken Nugget* holds the potential to defuse the established with the radical. *“The imaginary is the potential of what the self might be, and this imaginary self is always a product of culture and ideology, not of the universal nature of the human psyche”*.<sup>13</sup> The exaggerated performances and sharp comedic timing of the actors

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<sup>11</sup> Packer, J. and Stoneman, E. (2018) ‘The Tragicomic Pessimism of Rick and Morty’, in *A Feeling of Wrongness*. University Park, Pennsylvania: The Pennsylvania State University Press, pp. 79–106. Available at: [https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.5325/j.ctv14gp13w?turn\\_away=true](https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.5325/j.ctv14gp13w?turn_away=true) (Accessed: 18 June 2024).

<sup>12</sup> Heritage, S. (2024) ‘it’s so weird’: The TV show about a woman who turns into a Chicken Nugget (2024) *The Guardian*. Available at: <https://www.theguardian.com/tv-and-radio/2024/mar/15/its-so-weird-the-tv-show-about-a-woman-who-turns-into-a-chicken-nugget> (Accessed: 10 June 2024).

<sup>13</sup> Fiske, J. (1985) ‘The Semiotics of Television’, *Critical Studies in Mass Communication*, 2(2), pp. 176–183. doi:10.1080/15295038509360076. (Accessed: 10 June 2024)

present profoundly emotional realities with a surreal, extraterrestrial backdrop, inviting (or rather forcing) the viewer to find themselves based on their subjectivity, media literacy and cultural learnings.

The South Korean drama industry has seen growth in its global viewership since the 90s, and this growth has gone through a great surge over the last decade due to OTT platforms<sup>14</sup> such as Disney+ and Netflix.<sup>15,16</sup> Part of this growth is thanks to English subtitles becoming available - often in the form of fan submissions.<sup>17</sup> This is another way in which television today demands a relational viewing. By perceiving it as a medium that only existed to bring a piece of content closer to its intended audience<sup>18</sup>, we begin to see it as a space that provides artistic content and relies on inter-human networks for its consumption. Bourriaud's neglect of not viewing television as a relational medium could then be seen as an implicit reinforcement of the distinction between high and low art. I am refusing this distinction and adhering to the aesthetic and cultural qualities that inform the contemporary landscape of television. In both the above cases, the detached abstraction of reality in the visual representations of objects as humans was cut through with a consistent emotional core built into the relationality and realism of inter-human relationships. Where could we potentially place an audience in case of transforming them into the object?

## Human-to-object in Interactive Arts

As I previously quoted Bourriaud, form is the representation of desire. In this sense, the art object is the manifestation of said desire; the one (creator) offering it creates possibility of encounters while the one (viewer) receiving it, builds the conditions for this exchange. Immersive and interactive artworks promote such encounters. These mediums tend to centre the experience of the

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<sup>14</sup> Over-the-top (OTT) media service (also known as streaming platform) is a media service offered directly to viewers via the Internet.

<sup>15</sup> Kim, R. (2024) Korean drama fans say the shows have changed – and there's 1 big reason, HuffPost UK. Available at: [https://www.huffingtonpost.co.uk/entry/korean-drama-how-streaming-has-changed-netflix\\_uk\\_664c95fae4b0f45dcbad5b48](https://www.huffingtonpost.co.uk/entry/korean-drama-how-streaming-has-changed-netflix_uk_664c95fae4b0f45dcbad5b48) (Accessed: 24 June 2024).

<sup>16</sup> Min-sik, Y. (2022) K-dramas: The making of a global breakthrough, The Korea Herald. Available at: <https://www.koreaherald.com/view.php?ud=20220811000338> (Accessed: 23 June 2024).

<sup>17</sup> Locher, M.A. (2020) 'Moments of relational work in English fan translations of Korean TV drama', *Journal of Pragmatics*, 170, pp. 139–155. doi:10.1016/j.pragma.2020.08.002. (Accessed: 25 June 2024)

<sup>18</sup> Bretz, R. (1950) 'TV as an art form', *Hollywood Quarterly*, 5(2), pp. 153–163. doi:10.2307/1209446. (Accessed: 18 June 2024).

viewer, which typically means that embodiment of such experiences holds the key to a successful viewing.

### Exhibition of interaction

In 1995, Char Davies, a Canadian media artist, produced an immersive interactive virtual reality installation titled, *Osmose*. Davies' exploration of embodiment in virtual reality work was rooted in her commitment to phenomenology and sensuality. She did so in contrast with her peers as well as recent media artists who focus their creative energy towards fantastical, disembodied and technically oriented works. "*Osmose is a space for exploring the perceptual interplay between self and world, i.e., a place for facilitating awareness of one's own self as consciousness embodied in enveloping space*".<sup>19</sup> Immersants<sup>20</sup> in this work were able to move based on breathing and balance, which added a heightened sense of embodiment. The concept of breath-based interaction is based on divers<sup>21</sup> and creates an interaction so primal that it automatically produces a corporeal experience. Mathew Ratcliffe, a phenomenologist, writes about the "feeling body" in his text, *The Feeling of Being*. He writes about lived, physical experience as the locator of self in the world; it acts as a background to how we experience objects instead of being an object of experience itself.<sup>22</sup> Immersants are thus able to locate themselves in their experience of *Osmose* through their "feeling body".<sup>23</sup>

Another aspect of existing in this work was the exhibition of the immersed body. To bring attention to the body's role as ground and medium in *Osmose*, she created a shadow-silhouette of the immersant alongside the real-time projection.<sup>24</sup> Through this element, she adds another form of encounter for us to dissect. I would argue that in this form, she is instigating the exchange of human and art object. By becoming a spectacle, the immersant becomes the art object.

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<sup>19</sup> Davies, C. (1995) *Osmose*. Available at: <http://www.immersence.com/osmose/> (Accessed: 10 January 2024).

<sup>20</sup> "Immersant" is a term coined by Davies in reference to users within immersive experiences.

<sup>21</sup> Davies, C. (1995) *Osmose*. Available at: <http://www.immersence.com/osmose/> (Accessed: 10 January 2024)

<sup>22</sup> Ratcliffe, M., 2005. *The Feeling of Being*. *Journal of Consciousness Studies*, 12(8-9), pp.43-60. (Accessed: 18 January 2024)

<sup>23</sup> Thwaites, H. (2006) *The Immersive Experience of Osmose and Ephémère: An Audience Study*, Immersance. Available at: <https://immersence.com/publications/2006/2006-HThwaites.html> (Accessed: 18 June 2024).

<sup>24</sup> Davies, C. (2003) *Rethinking VR: Key Concepts and Concerns*, Immersance. Available at: <http://www.immersence.com/publications/char/2003-CD-VSSM.html> (Accessed: 18 June 2024).



*“I have always emphasised the idea of perceptual relativity between the person who has the experience and the rest of the world, rather than interactivity dependent upon something”.*<sup>25</sup> Although the installation was designed to be a solitary experience, through her desire to create encounters between the work and non-immersants, she creates the possibility of a human-to-object phenomenon.

### Creation based on interaction

An example of this principle could also be found in a work by the Australian artist, Simon Penny, and his collaborators<sup>26</sup>. They created *Traces* in 1999; an interactive artwork designed to bring the human body entirely into the virtual space.<sup>27</sup> This work was situated in a CAVE environment<sup>28</sup> displaying simulated visual imagery on all surfaces of the room as well as in the headset of the user. It was presented as networked experiences for multiple solitary users, meaning that multiple CAVEs could be activated simultaneously. In this scenario, each user could interact with image traces formed by the others in real time. These image traces were based in real time data collected by a multi-camera setup. This visual tracking system was employed to compute each user’s spatial and temporal presence and model three-dimensional figures made of voxels<sup>29</sup>. *“Unlike other VR projects, I have no interest here in illusionistic texture mapped models, the illusion of infinite virtual space or building “virtual worlds”. All attention is focused on the ongoing bodily behavior of the user”.*<sup>30</sup> By forming material based on active user engagement, *Traces* presents a playful yet meditative opportunity at embodiment in a virtual space.

In his paper on contemporary theories of embodiment in interactive arts, Nathaniel Stern asserts that embodiment is relational and rooted in interactivity. He evidences this by analysing *Traces* under his proposed framework, the “implicit body framework”, which concentrates on analysing an artwork in four key

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<sup>25</sup> Davies, C., 1997 *“Osmose.”* Nov’Art: The General Assembly on Inter@active Writing. (February, 1997), pp. 34-37, (Accessed: 10 June 2024).

<sup>26</sup> Collaborators include Jeffrey Smith, Phoebe Sengers, Andre Bernhardt and Jamieson Shulte.

<sup>27</sup> Penny, S. (2020) *Traces*, SimonPenny.net. Available at: <https://simonpenny.net/works/traces.html> (Accessed: 10 January 2024).

<sup>28</sup> CAVE refers to an immersive virtual reality environment where projectors are directed to between three and six of the walls of a room-sized cube.

<sup>29</sup> A voxel is a three-dimensional counterpart to a pixel.

<sup>30</sup> Penny, S. (2020) *Traces*, SimonPenny.net. Available at: <https://simonpenny.net/works/traces.html> (Accessed: 10 January 2024).

areas: artistic inquiry and process; artwork description; interactivity; and relationality. I will be focusing on his readings of the last two areas. The implicit body framework requires us to read precise movements and moments of physical interaction with the artwork as opposed to recorded testaments on embodiment. *“While the process of embodiment itself resists being captured or presented in text or images, it is precisely this resistance that the implicit body framework attempts to address”*.<sup>31</sup> In *Traces* this is revealed in the forms assumed by the visual simulations. By forming shapes based on body information rather than representational imagery, it depicts the embodied experience of interactivity. And this brings us to its relational reading. As the images created in *Traces* represent the body’s activity instead of the body, they are processual and performative in nature hence making meaning from the outside-inside relational space.<sup>32</sup>

The performative axis of exhibiting one’s audience in a work aligns with Davies’ ideology.<sup>33</sup> Looking back at *Osmose*, although the immersant lacks a virtual body - due to its corporeal demand of interaction via breathing and movement, I would posit that it adheres to Stern’s notions of interactivity as embodiment. *Osmose* and *Traces* both included generative and exhibitivite aspects that employ the experience of embodiment. Hence, the relational view of embodiment within immersive and interactive arts reveals the human-to-object experience.

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<sup>31</sup> Stern, N. (2011) ‘The implicit body as performance: Analyzing interactive art’, *Leonardo*, 44(3), pp. 233–238. doi:10.1162/leon\_a\_00168. (Accessed: 20 March 2024)

<sup>32</sup> Stern, N. (2011) ‘The implicit body as performance: Analyzing interactive art’, *Leonardo*, 44(3), pp. 233–238. doi:10.1162/leon\_a\_00168. (Accessed: 20 March 2024)

<sup>33</sup> Davies, C. (2003) *Rethinking VR: Key Concepts and Concerns*, Immersance. Available at: <http://www.immersence.com/publications/char/2003-CD-VSSM.html> (Accessed: 18 June 2024).

## Conclusion

Object-to-human expressions are taking place on television via signs and meaning expressed in the narrative and exaggerated in popular productions through inter-human networks that grow and internally organise affect. Human-to-object experiences take place in immersive, interactive works through the embodiment of the audience based on their interaction with the work and proximity to the presentation of said embodiment. What connects these distinct mediums is the relational reading of their consumption. “What they (artists) produce are relational space-time elements, inter-human experiences trying to rid themselves of the straitjacket of the ideology of mass communications, in a way, of the places where alternative forms of sociability, critical models and moments of constructed conviviality are worked out”.<sup>34</sup>

Such artistic endeavours present encounters between the organic and the inorganic as an opportunity to revisit how we address the relationship between the two: “the neutral is the third term between organic and inorganic that allows oneself not to fix unduly on one of the two poles and, at the same time, keeps them both active”.<sup>35</sup> From *Traces* to *Chicken Nugget*, we saw expressions that implore the viewer to empathise with the lack of a recognisable human body. In *Osmose* and *Pickle Rick*, we were introduced to modified expressions of the human body that demand our understanding and analysis of their realities. By encouraging such radical viewing of the human experience, flowing fluidly between the organic and the inorganic, we encounter renewed ways of viewing ourselves in the world.

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<sup>34</sup> Bourriaud, N. (1998) *Relational Aesthetics*. Dijon, Burgundy: Les Presses du Réel. (Accessed: 10 January 2024)

<sup>35</sup> Bianchi, E. (2020) 'The adventures of the thing: Mario Perniola's sex appeal of the Inorganic', *AM Journal of Art and Media Studies*, (22), pp. 23–34. doi:10.25038/am.v0i22.380. (Accessed: 20 February 2024)

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